INDIA TODAY RPG Happiness Quest

It Takes *A Village...*

...to show how to keep Covid at bay. Welcome to Veewan, a remote hamlet in Kashmir

By **MOAZUM MOHAMMAD** IN SRINAGAR



PANDEMIC-PROOF Healthcare workers at Veewan

ABID BHAT

Unbelievable but true: a village in Kashmir has remained Covid-free through three waves of the pandemic. The remote village of Veewan in north Kashmir's Bandipora district—currently under a blanket of snow—has an adult population of 362. Wali Mohammad, a health official who was deputed to the village last July to conduct Covid tests, recounts: "The village is inaccessible. We trekked 17 km on foot to get there," says the 47-year-old paramedic. "Not a single resident was apprehensive about Covid and people were engrossed in their daily routines."

It was the time Bandipora was emerging as a Covid hotspot. Veewan, located 28 km from the district headquarters, was feared to be affected. According to Dr Masarat Iqbal Wani, the district nodal officer for Covid, a team was sent to Veewan. The team started door-to-door Covid testing and issued guidelines. Masks, hand sanitisers and medicines were distributed. "It would have been disastrous had the virus spread here since supplying oxygen to the village would have been impossible," says Wani.

HAPPINESS MANTRA

"We are determined to beat Covid. All adults and eligible teenagers here have taken the vaccine"

—ALI MOHAMMAD, RESIDENT OF VEEWAN

The team did not find any infected individual. This was attributed to the remoteness of the village and its thin population. "In January this year, we camped in the village for three days and conducted 275 Covid tests," says Mohd Wali. "Last year, we conducted 265 tests. None tested positive on both occasions."

When the administration began door-to-door vaccination for Covid, Wali and his team reached Veewan again. The villagers, he says, overcame vaccine hesitancy after being counselled. In July last year, Veewan shot into prominence for becoming the first village to have fully vaccinated its eligible population against Covid. The achievement drew applause from Prime Minister Narendra Modi. The village is basking in glory again. On January 16, a health team trudged through knee-deep snow to vaccinate all eligible 15 to 18-year-olds of Veewan. ■

BEATING SOCIAL MEDIA BLUES

BE AWARE: It is important to be mindful about how you use social media. Avoid it when it's negatively impacting you.

EXERCISE WILLPOWER: Improve your willpower to say 'no'. Do not give in to social pressure and stay obsessed with your social media feed. Set boundaries for usage and stick to them.

SEEK HELP: If you are unable to resist the temptation, turn to a friend or family member for assistance. Having support from your dear ones can really help in such situations.

TURN OFF NOTIFICATIONS: Fix a time in the day for social media rather than indulge in it every time there is a notification. Keep it off at night time and early morning.

TRY THERAPY: If you feel you are addicted to social media and it is affecting your wellbeing, seek professional help. Therapy can go a long way in helping you find balance and positivity online.



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-As told to Sonali Acharjee

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